

the outside and seaming and decking in the middle? With India in 2003, Wright remembers the tour, "all too clearly" but says those were 'extraordinary' conditions. "I'm confident those conditions won't be replicated to such an extent." His old India captain thinks differently. "India will get seaming wickets, they shouldn't expect tracks that suit them," says Ganguly.

Even in the normal realm, New Zealand is an uncommon place: mortals talk about raising the bat on its back lift only to find the wind pushing it down. On his seventh tour of New Zealand, Sachin Tendulkar, the HRH himself, knows that the country is one part beguiling charm and three parts challenge, "With the wind behind the bowler, it affects the batsman as he can't keep his eyes open for long." In towns like Wellington where India play a T-20 international, an ODI and a Test, when bowlers run in, the gusts sometimes fill their eyes with tears.

It's not how India wants this tour

INDIA'S SCHEDULE IN NEW ZEALAND

Feb 25	1st T-20 International, Christchurch
Feb 27	2nd T-20 International, Wellington
Mar 3	1st ODI, Napier
Mar 6	2nd ODI, Wellington
Mar 8	3rd ODI, Christchurch
Mar 11	4th ODI, Hamilton
Mar 14	5th ODI, Auckland
Mar 18-22	1st Test, Hamilton
Mar 26-30	2nd Test, Napier
Apr 3-7	3rd Test, Wellington

“India's test will start now; the next two seasons will decide where they will go as a team.”

SOURAV GANGULY,
former Indian captain

INDIA'S TEST RECORD IN NEW ZEALAND

YEAR	P	W	L	D	CAPTAIN
1967-68	4	3	1	0	Pataudi
1975-76	3	1	1	1	Gavaskar
1980-81	3	0	1	2	Gavaskar
1989-90	2	0	1	1	Azharuddin
1993-94	1	0	0	1	Azharuddin
1998-99	2	0	1	1	Azharuddin
2002-03	2	0	2	0	Ganguly

INDIA'S ONE-DAY RECORD IN NEW ZEALAND

YEAR	P	W	L	D
1976-2003	30	9	20	1

VVS LAXMAN AND RAHUL DRAVID (FAR LEFT); SACHIN TENDULKAR (LEFT)

to end. No doubt the phrase 'controlling the controllables' will be circulating in the team room like a tempest. It is the kind of place where Wright, a former Test opener, says, "you've got to be patient—you have to fight for your runs". It sounds like just the job for Rahul Dravid to take his mind away from his record after quitting the Indian captaincy (at 30.81, only seven scores above 50 in 36 innings). Dravid says New Zealand is a place not for over-deliberation but for execution. "You can't overcomplicate your batting. You need to go there, judge the conditions, the state of the game and just bat." Lalchand Rajput, who coached the India under-19s in 2007, says the conditions require sound shot selection. "We can't play on the up, we must drive only if the ball is on the up or you'll be in trouble."

Being overdaunted by the conditions in New Zealand is probably as bad as being underdaunted by the opposition. If there's a place that Kiwis can actually fly, it is their home turf. Dravid says, "They tend to have bowlers who are ideal for those conditions, virtually from ground to ground." And a clutch of previously unheralded batsmen who stick it out for just long enough to make it count.

Following a New Zealand tour for the average fan routinely involves waking at sunrise to discover with utter dismay that India are 67-4. But former India batsman Sanjay Manjrekar will be watching what he believes is going to be a nuts and bolts tour on which "the mechanics of India's cricket, the basics ability of its batting, bowling and slip catching is going to be tested".

As also its resolve and roadworthiness. Wright is waiting for India to land and says to his old team, "You must put pressure on yourselves to get results. You don't go overseas to compete, you go to win." Should the final frontier be conquered, India will actually have taken their first step in their heady quest for greatness. ■

For related stories, click
www.indiatoday.in/nztour



Photographs by AP